

Cambridge Lower Secondary Checkpoint

ENGLISH**0861/01**

Paper 1 Non-fiction

May 2026

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1 hour 10 minutes

INFORMATION

- This insert contains the reading text.
- You may annotate this insert and use the blank spaces for planning. **Do not write your answers** on the insert.



This document has **4** pages. Any blank pages are indicated.

Text for **Section A****The Tinkers of Slovakia**

Mention tinkers in Slovakia nowadays, and most people think of nomadic menders of pots and pans. Travel though tinkers did, they were also highly skilled artisans who created from wire and tin an astounding variety of utilitarian and decorative goods. Legend has it that Slovak tinkers once constructed a bridge of silver wire that spanned the River Danube. Though this fantastical legend holds no basis in fact, it does suggest the high regard in which tinkers and their remarkable skills were once held. 5

'You undoubtedly have at least five things in your kitchen that were once made by Slovak tinkers,' master tinker Ladislav Jurovaty, a rangy, attractive man in his mid-70s, tells me. 10
'Whisks, sieves, baskets, trays, cake tins, ladles and biscuit cutters were just some of the many things that tinkers made.'

Jurovaty is at the Povazske Museum in Zilina, Slovakia. Housed in Budatin Castle, on the outskirts of town, the museum holds a collection of some 1200 pieces of tinker wares, tools, wires, documents and photographs. This June weekend, about 40 tinkers from both the Slovak and Czech Republics have gathered at Budatin Castle for its annual tinker conference. First held in 1992, the conference strives to preserve the tinker craft. It is a craft long in danger of disappearing, along with its remaining old-time practitioners. These specialists want to spark the interest of the next generation. 15

Zilina is in north-western Slovakia, near one of the two regions where most Slovak tinkers were born. The other, in the north-eastern region of Spis, has a short tinkering history; little is known about the tinkers in that area. In north-western Slovakia, though, an area of about 150 villages gave birth to most of the tinkers who for centuries travelled the world, practising their craft. In fact, the region came to be known as Drotaria, or Tinker Country, from 'drotar', Slovak for tinker. 20

Two things contributed to this impoverished mountainous region becoming the cradle of the tinker trade: a terrain unfavourable to agriculture and a proximity to Silesia, with its iron works and wire-drawing mills. In the late 15th century, wire in this region was already being put to new use. 25

At that time, Jurovaty explains, workers in the iron works and mines carried their daily meals in ceramic pots. Because these vessels often broke, workers bound the pots in wire nets to hold them together. The nets also kept broken pot pieces together for easy mending. This simple wire netting technique was the birth of the tinker craft. 30

The early tinkers offered this service to family, friends, neighbours and villagers. Soon they were travelling from village to village, taking orders for all sorts of different types of wire products. For centuries, mousetraps were a mainstay of the tinker trade, which continued to spread as tinkering skills developed. 35

These were passed from generation to generation; father and son often worked together. From making and mending simple pieces, soon Slovak tinkers were producing a wide range of practical, inexpensive and decorative wire and metal articles. The ornamental details of these items were drawn mostly from Slovak folk art. These included plant and animal motifs and patterns much like those found in Slovak lace-making. 40

Weaving, twisting or looping plain iron or zinc-coated wire, tinkers used a 'cold' process, without welding or soldering, to form their wares. With their toolboxes on their backs, Slovak tinkers travelled first throughout the Austro-Hungarian Empire and then all over Europe, wiring farm implements, mending broken pottery and porcelain pipes as well as creating tin kitchen utensils. 45

In the early 19th century, about two-thirds of the male population in Drotaria, were tinkers. With the occurrence of mass emigration in the mid-19th century, tinkers travelled to virtually every continent in the world, adapting themselves to local markets. Where demand for their craft was greatest the tinkers went into business, setting up workshops and factories to produce and sell their wares. Workshops flourished in many cities: Tunis, Moscow, Warsaw, Budapest, Zurich, Brussels, Philadelphia and Buenos Aires.

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Tinker products were geared to local demand, be it for wire birdcages, chandeliers, toys or mangers for goats. In the United States, says Jurovaty, there are still about 20 workshops manufacturing birdcages today. And, he adds, it was the Brodek brothers, two Slovak tinkers, who designed the wheeled shopping trolley.

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During the early 20th century, with the introduction of mass-produced items, tinkers struggled to keep their traditional skills alive and by the end of the century, the craft all but disappeared. Recently, there has been a resurgence of interest in tinkering. Expert tinkers like Jurovaty are meeting together to try to raise public awareness and encourage a new generation of skilled wireworkers. Jurovaty admits it's hard to say what the future holds for the resurgent craft of tinkering, but the number of young tinkers is growing. 'My son says that once you start working with wire,' Jurovaty laughs, 'it's impossible to stop.'

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